

WEEK 1 · AWS

Decision or delivery?

AWS consultancy and AWS managed services sound alike. They are two different purchases. This playbook helps you buy the one you actually need.

INSIDE

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A practical guide to buying the right kind of AWS help. Read it end to end, or jump to the worksheet before your next supplier conversation.

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INTRODUCTION

Two purchases that sound the same.

Most AWS conversations start with a vague request for help. The first job is to decide which kind of help you are buying, because the contract, the team and the measure of success are all different.

Consultancy buys a decision

Advice, design and a defined piece of work that ends with a clear recommendation or a finished change.

A managed service buys delivery

A team that runs the estate every day: monitoring, patching, backups, support and cost reporting against agreed service levels.

Mixing them up is expensive

Buy advice when you needed operations and nothing gets run. Buy operations when you needed a decision and you pay to run the wrong thing well.

01

PART 01

Know the difference.

Side by side, the two look nothing alike once you ask what you get at the end.

01 Consultancy vs managed service

02 When you need a consultancy

03 When you need a managed service

SIDE BY SIDE

What you are actually buying

Use this table to test any proposal. If the answers on the page do not match the column you meant to buy, stop and ask why.

	CONSULTANCY	MANAGED SERVICE
The outcome	A decision, a design or a completed project.	An estate that is run, watched and improved every day.
Duration	Fixed. It has a start, an end and a handover.	Ongoing. It renews and evolves with the business.
How it is priced	By project, phase or day rate.	By a recurring service fee, usually tied to scope.
Success looks like	A clear recommendation you can act on.	Service levels met, incidents handled, costs kept in check.
Who owns the outcome	You own the decision. They own the quality of the advice.	They own day to day operations. You own the priorities.
Typical deliverables	Assessments, architecture, migration plans, a cost or security review.	Monitoring, patching, backup, support desk, monthly reporting.
When it ends	When the work is delivered and handed over.	When you choose to exit, using the exit plan agreed up front.

SIGNALS

When you need a consultancy

You need a decision, a design or a one-off change, and you have, or will have, people to run what comes after.

You are planning a move

A migration, a re-platform or a new region, and you need a plan the board can sign off.

Something needs a second opinion

A cost, security or resilience review before you commit more budget.

The architecture has drifted

The estate grew project by project and nobody can explain the whole design any more.

A decision is waiting on evidence

Leaders want options, risks and a recommendation, not a running service.

Ask: at the end of this work, what decision will we be able to make that we cannot make today?

SIGNALS

When you need a managed service

You know what the estate should look like. What is missing is the capacity to run it well, every day.

Alerts go unanswered

Monitoring exists, but nobody is clearly responsible for acting on it out of hours.

Patching and backups slip

Routine work loses to project work, and the gaps only show during an incident.

Your team is firefighting

Skilled engineers spend their week on tickets instead of the roadmap.

Cost needs watching, not fixing once

Spend creeps back after every clean-up because nobody reviews it each month.

> Ask: who will run this at two in the morning, and how will we know it was handled?

02

PART 02

Avoid the costly mistakes.

Most problems come from buying one kind of help and expecting the other.

01 Five common mistakes

02 Questions to ask before you buy

03 Decision worksheet

COMMON MISTAKES

Five ways the purchase goes wrong

Each of these is common, and each is avoidable with one clear conversation before the contract is signed.

01 **Expecting a consultancy to run things**

The report lands, the team leaves and nobody is responsible for the changes it recommended.

02 **Expecting a managed service to set strategy**

The estate runs smoothly in the wrong direction because nobody owns the design decisions.

03 **Scoping by hours, not outcomes**

Time gets used, but the decision or the service level you needed is never defined.

04 **No handover or exit plan**

Knowledge leaves with the supplier, or switching later becomes painful and slow.

05 **Nobody owns the cost**

Advice and operations both assume the other side is watching the bill.

REMEMBER

Many organisations need both, in sequence: a consultancy to decide what good looks like, then a managed service to keep it that way.

BEFORE YOU BUY

Questions to take into the room

Ask these of any AWS partner. Clear, specific answers are a good sign. Vague ones tell you what you need to know.

ASK A CONSULTANCY

- ? What decision or deliverable will we have at the end?
- ? Who on your team will do the work, and who will we hand over to?
- ? How will you leave us able to run what you design?
- ? What is explicitly out of scope?

ASK A MANAGED SERVICE PROVIDER

- ? What are the service levels, and how are they reported?
- ? Who responds out of hours, and how quickly?
- ? How do you report and control our AWS cost each month?
- ? What does exit look like if we part ways?

WORKSHEET

Which one do you need?

Tick the statements that are true today. Mostly in the first group points to consultancy. Mostly in the second points to a managed service. A mix usually means both, in that order.

- [ ] **We do not yet know what the estate should look like**
  Points to consultancy.

- [ ] **A board or leadership decision is waiting on options**
  Points to consultancy.

- [ ] **We need an independent cost or security review**
  Points to consultancy.

- [ ] **We know the target, but lack people to run it**
  Points to a managed service.

- [ ] **Alerts, patching or backups are slipping**
  Points to a managed service.

- [ ] **We need cover outside working hours**
  Points to a managed service.

- [ ] **Cost creeps back after every clean-up**
  Points to a managed service with monthly cost reporting.

TRANSPUTEC

Not sure which you need?

Start with a short conversation. We will help you work out whether you need a decision, someone to run the estate, or both.

Talk to our AWS team

transputec.com